

As Party Meets,
Xi Embodies
Imperial Rule

Resolute Despite Covid
and Fiscal Malaise

By CHRIS BUCKLEY

In his first years as China’s leader, Xi Jinping paid for his own steamed dumplings in a cheap diner, casually rolled up his trouser legs to avoid splashes in the rain, and was serenaded with sugary pop tunes. His image-makers cast him as “Xi Dada,” the people’s firm but genial “Uncle Xi.”

How vastly different now. A decade on, Mr. Xi looms over the country like a stern Communist monarch, reflecting on China’s fallen ancient dynasties and determined to win its lasting ascendancy in a turbulent world.

Chinese officials praise his speeches like hallowed texts, professing loyalty with a fervor that sometimes echoes Mao Zedong’s era. Privately mocking Mr. Xi can lead to prison. His public encounters are regimented displays of acclaim.

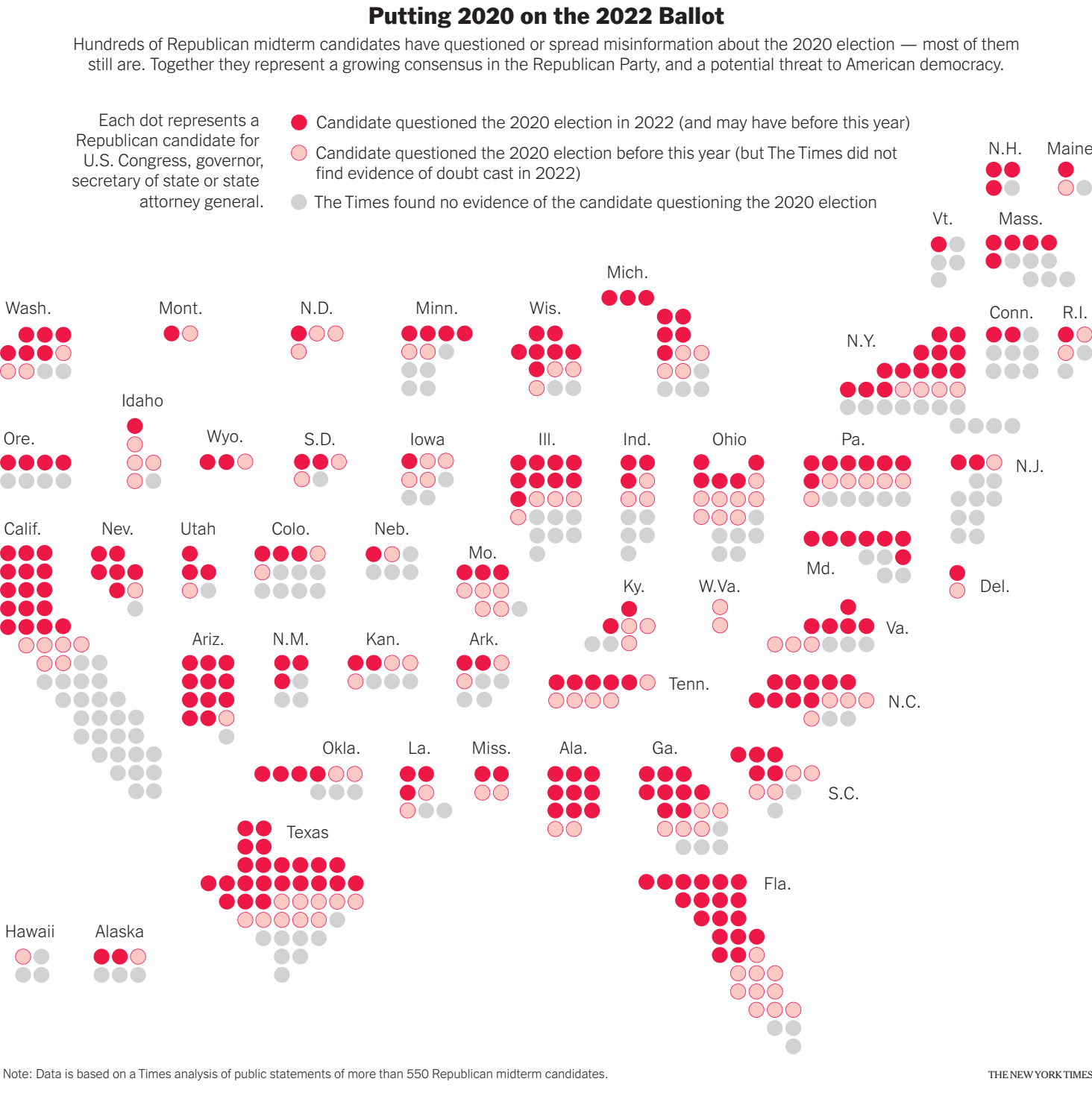
A Communist Party congress opening Sunday is shaping up to be Mr. Xi’s imperial moment, strengthening and extending his rule, while also intensifying the long-term hazards from his singular dominance. At the meeting in Beijing, he seems sure of winning a third term as the party’s general secretary, breaking with recent expectations that Chinese leaders would reign for around a decade.

“The certainty will really only be in the arrangements at the top-most level, that his power is beyond challenge, but beneath that we’ll face a great many uncertainties,” Wu Qiang, a political analyst in Beijing, said in an interview.

The evolution of Mr. Xi’s public face has paralleled his transformation of China into a proudly authoritarian state, scornful of criticism from Washington, increasingly sure that Western democracy has lost its allure, and impatient for a bigger say in shaping the 21st-century global order.

The party congress will be Mr. Xi’s stage to demonstrate that he remains undaunted, despite the recent economic malaise, Covid outbreaks and increasing animosity with the United States, which has labeled China a national security threat. He is likely to tell the

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2020 Election Skeptics Crowd the Republican Ticket Nationwide

This article is by **Karen Yourish, Danielle Ivory, Weiyei Cai, Nick Corasaniti and Jonathan Weisman.**

They include candidates for the U.S. House and Senate, and the state offices of governor, secretary of state and attorney general — many with clear shots to victory, and some without a chance. They are united by at least one issue: They have all expressed doubt about the legitimacy of the 2020 election. And they are the new normal of the Republican Party.

More than 370 people — a vast majority of Republicans running for these offices in November — have questioned and, at times, outright denied the results of the 2020 election despite overwhelming evidence to the contrary, according to a monthslong New York Times investigation. These candidates represent a sentiment that is spreading in the Republican Party, rupturing a bedrock principle of democracy: that voters decide elections and candidates accept results.

This skepticism has stretched into political races in every state and is still frequently being raised as a campaign issue, The Times has found, nearly two years after Donald J. Trump was defeated.

Over 370 Candidates Have Voiced Doubts About the Results

Hundreds of these candidates are favored to win their races.

Far from fading over time, as many Americans had hoped, election lies and misinformation have proved strikingly resilient, even amid a political campaign season in which far more is being said by candidates and their party officials about issues like inflation and abortion. The Times has for the first time identified more than 240 candidates who are still casting doubt on the presidential election.

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Late Edition

Today, plenty of sunshine, breezy, mild, high 69. Tonight, partly cloudy, low 53. Tomorrow, a mixture of clouds and sunshine, still mild, high 66. Weather map is on Page B12.

**AFTER BLOWBACK,
BRITAIN REVERSES
ECONOMIC COURSE**

PERILS OF BIG TAX CUTS

Central Banks Proposing
Subtler Maneuvers to
Combat Inflation

By PATRICIA COHEN

LONDON — Government leaders in the West are struggling with rising inflation, slowing growth, and anxious electorates worried about winter and high energy bills. But Liz Truss, Britain’s prime minister, is the only one who devised an economic plan that unnerved financial markets, drew the ire of global leaders and the public and undermined her political standing.

On Friday, battered by savage criticism, she retreated. Ms. Truss fired her top finance official, Kwasi Kwarteng, for creating precisely the package of unfunded tax cuts, billion-dollar spending programs and deregulation that she had asked for.

She reinstated a scheduled increase in corporate taxes to 25 percent from 19 percent, a rise she had previously opposed. That announcement came on top of backtracking last week on her proposal to eliminate the top 45 percent income tax on the highest earners. The prime minister, in office a little over five weeks, also promised that spending would grow less rapidly than proposed, although no specifics were offered.

The drama is still playing out, and it’s unclear if the Truss government will survive.

In the United States, President Biden, while waging his own political battles over gas prices and inflation, has not proposed anything like the kind of policies that Ms. Truss’s government attempted, nor have any other leaders in Europe.

Still, for European governments whose economies are suffering greatly from shocks and energy price surges caused by Russia’s war in Ukraine, there are timely lessons from the debacle playing out in London.

One of the strongest was delivered early on by the International

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Protest and Prayers Became a ‘Massacre’ in Iran

This article is by **Cora Engelbrecht, Nilo Tabrizy and Ishaan Jhaveri.**

Some of the wounded tried to crawl away to escape the gunfire. Others bled to death on prayer mats as people tried to drag them to safety.

But the snipers and officers kept pulling their triggers, firing bullet after bullet into men and young boys at a worship area where Friday Prayer had been underway.

The horrific scene unfolded on Sept. 30 in Zahedan, a city in southeastern Iran that is home to the ethnic Baluch minority, after a small group of worshipers emerged from the Great Mosalla prayer complex to confront security forces posted at a police station across the street.

The protesters chanted anti-government slogans and threw rocks at the officers, prompting the security forces to fire indiscriminately into the crowd, according to witnesses. As the demonstrators scattered, the gunshots stalked their retreat back toward the complex, where thousands were still praying.

“It was a massacre I had only seen in movies,” said Jamshid, 28, a worshiper, who was reached by phone and identified himself only by his first name to avoid reprisals. “They started shooting as

Furor Unmasks
A Caste System
Among Latinos

By MIRIAM JORDAN

LOS ANGELES — Ivan Vasquez arrived in Los Angeles in 1996, a teenager who had crossed the border to find work and improve the lot of his family in Mexico. As a newbie washing dishes in restaurants, the young man from the majority Indigenous state of Oaxaca was often called “Oaxaquita,” or Little Oaxacan, by other Mexicans because of his deep tan skin and diminutive stature.

Still, he eventually rose to become a regional manager at Baja Fresh and opened his own restaurant in 2013, a celebration of his native state’s unique cuisine. Powered by mole and mezcal, the restaurant, Madre, has won rave reviews from food critics and grown to three locations in a city that embraces multiculturalism.

So Mr. Vasquez, now 41, was shocked this week to hear disparaging remarks about Oaxacans from Nury Martinez, a powerful Latina politician who was president of the City Council.

A recording of a closed-door meeting in 2021, in which Ms. Martinez was heard referring to

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Discovery by Chaucer Scholars
Scrubs Stain From His Legacy

By JENNIFER SCHUESSLER

For nearly 150 years, a cloud has hung over the reputation of Geoffrey Chaucer, the author of “The Canterbury Tales,” long seen as the founder of the English literary canon.

A court document discovered in 1873 suggested that around 1380, Chaucer had been charged with raping Cecily Chaucapaigne, the daughter of a London baker. In the document, Chaumpaigne released Chaucer from “all manner of actions related to my raptus” — a word commonly translated as rape or abduction.

In recent decades, the suggestion that Chaucer had been accused of rape helped inspire a rich vein of feminist criticism looking at sex, power and consent in stories like “The Wife of Bath’s Tale” and “The Miller’s Tale,” which contain depictions of sexual assault (or what to modern readers appears like it).

But this week, two scholars stunned the world of Chaucer studies with previously unknown documents that they say show that the “raptus” document was not in fact related to an accusation of rape against Chaucer at all.

The new documents, the two scholars say, establish that the one that surfaced in the 1870s had

INTERNATIONAL A4-12

Two Different Wars

As Russia continues to bombard Kyiv from the air, Ukrainian ground troops are reclaiming territory. PAGE A5

Chinese Doctor’s Final Days

A Times investigation details the death of Dr. Li Wenliang, who sounded an early alarm on Covid-19. PAGE A10

NATIONAL A13-21

Rampage Unnerves Raleigh

A 15-year-old boy was in custody as investigators searched for a motive in a shooting that killed an off-duty police officer along with four others. PAGE A20

Appeal to Stop Special Master

The government asked a court to end a special master review of the files hoarded by the ex-president. PAGE A17

Helping At-Risk Families

The Biden administration is proposing spending \$20 billion over a decade to help some of the most vulnerable families in the country. PAGE A13

BUSINESS B1-6

Seeking a \$24.6 Billion Merger

Kroger and Albertsons, two of the biggest U.S. grocery chains, announced a deal, which is likely to face tough federal scrutiny. PAGE B1

Waging a Battle Over Wages

More places are challenging a system that counts tips toward the minimum wage for service workers. PAGE B1

SPORTS B7-9

Yankees Wilt in Extra Innings

Pitcher Jameson Taillon was undone by defensive miscues, and the Guardians evened the playoff series at 1-1. PAGE B7

ARTS C1-12

Her Facets Can Now Shine

Unity Phelan’s fall season with New York City Ballet has shown her beauty and range in a string of debuts. PAGE C1

A Dickens Tale Reimagined

Barbara Kingsolver reinvents “David Copperfield” as a story of the opioid crisis in Southern Appalachia. PAGE C1

TO OUR READERS

The Return of ‘36 Hours’

With today’s newspaper, The New York Times is bringing back the popular Travel feature, which had been paused because of the pandemic. It will be just part of expanded Travel coverage in a weekly presentation in the Arts section, which also will include a “What to Cook” feature. SECTION C

OPINION A22-23

Jesse Wegman PAGE A23